WEEK 9 · LECTURE L1 · UNITS III AND IV

# Strengths Based Performance Management

Positive psychology, what a strength is, feedback intervention theory, and the critique that strengths can be overused.

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AFTER THIS LECTURE YOU SHOULD BE ABLE TO

# What this lecture prepares you for

- Explain the origins of the strengths approach and three definitions of a strength.
- Explain feedback intervention theory and why feedback sometimes harms performance.
- Describe the feedforward interview as a strengths based appraisal.
- Evaluate the overuse critique and the place of weaknesses.

**COURSE OUTCOMES**

CLO 1 (design performance management) and CLO 5 (create development programs).

COMMIT BEFORE THEORY

# Telling an employee clearly what is wrong with their work improves their performance.

True, false, or it depends on something you can name?

WHAT EXACTLY IS A STRENGTH?

# Three definitions, three systems

| Definition | What it is | What a system then does |
|---|---|---|
| **Clifton and Harter (2003)** | Talent multiplied by investment in knowledge and skill | Invest where talent is high |
| **Peterson and Seligman (2004)** | 24 character strengths under six virtues | Use signature strengths daily |
| **Linley (2008)** | A capacity that is authentic and energizing to use | Ask what energizes, not only what scores high |

**EXAM LENS**

Positive psychology (Seligman and Csikszentmihalyi, 2000) proposed studying what makes people flourish, not only what goes wrong.

THEORY IN DEPTH · KLUGER AND DENISI (1996)

# Feedback intervention theory

## THE CORE IDEA

Feedback improves performance on average, but in over a third of cases it reduced performance.

## HOW IT WORKS

Feedback moves attention. Toward the task, performance rises; toward the self, it falls as effort goes to protecting the self.

## LIMITS AND CRITIQUE

Much of the evidence comes from laboratory tasks; workplace feedback is more complex.

## IN PRACTICE

A public ranking or a weakness label pulls attention to the self, so performance may fall.

## EXAM LENS

Use it to explain why annual appraisal can backfire. Cite the 607 effect sizes and the harmful third.

A DESIGN BUILT ON THAT THEORY · KLUGER AND NIR (2010)

# The feedforward interview

### STORY OF SUCCESS

The employee describes a time at work when they were at their best

›

### CONDITIONS

Together, name what made it possible: actions, manager, setting

›

### FEEDFORWARD

How close is current work to those conditions?

›

### GOALS FROM THE GAP

Set goals from that distance, so attention stays on the task

Bouskila-Yam and Kluger (2011) built a strength based appraisal and goal setting process on this idea.

THEORY IN DEPTH · VAN WOERKOM AND MEYERS (2015)

# Does a strengths climate help?

### THE CORE IDEA

A climate that supports the use of strengths relates to positive affect and job performance.

### HOW IT WORKS

Employees who feel their organization supports strengths use report more positive affect, which links to performance.

### LIMITS AND CRITIQUE

Self reported, and much wider strengths evidence comes from the vendors who sell the assessments.

### IN PRACTICE

A team lead asks each person to spend part of the week on work that uses their strongest skill.

### EXAM LENS

Ask of any strengths claim: who measured it, against what comparison, and was the outcome performance or feeling good?

THE CRITIQUE

# Strengths can be overused

### GRANT AND SCHWARTZ (2011)

Many traits follow an inverted U: beyond a point, more of a strength harms performance.

### KAISER AND OVERFIELD (2011)

Leaders rated highly on a strength were often rated as overdoing it.

### AGUINIS, GOTTFREDSON AND JOO (2012)

Weaknesses that block the job must still be addressed: strengths first is a sequence.

COMPARE AND EVALUATE

# A long serving quality specialist, four theories

| Theory | What it sees | Design it implies |
|---|---|---|
| **Deficit model** | Gaps against a manager competency list | Training for leadership readiness |
| **Strengths (Clifton)** | Deep talent in precision and judgment | Invest further in the specialist domain |
| **Feedback intervention** | Threats to standing cost effort | Task focused feedback; no ranking talk |
| **Inverted U** | Rigor that can tip into resistance | Name the overuse risk with the strength |

PRACTICE FOR THE END TERM EXAMINATION

# Questions to rehearse

"Focusing on weaknesses is a waste of time." Critically evaluate the strengths based approach. **20 marks**

**A strong answer:** defines strengths; uses Kluger and DeNisi and Kluger and Nir; presents the overuse critique and Aguinis et al.; concludes with a sequence.

Design a strengths based appraisal for an Indian firm and identify its risks. **20 marks**

**A strong answer:** uses the feedforward interview; links goals to the gap; addresses manager skill, culture and overuse.

Why can feedback reduce performance? **10 marks**

**A strong answer:** explains the shift of attention to the self; cites the meta analysis; one example.

CARRY THESE INTO THE EXAMINATION

# Three things to remember

1. Feedback reduced performance in over a third of cases
2. Keep attention on the task, not the self
3. Strengths first is a sequence, not an amnesty for weaknesses

SET READINGS · FROM THE LESSON PLAN

# Read for this lecture

Buckingham, M., & Clifton, D. O. (2001). *Now, discover your strengths*. Free Press. Chapter 1.

Cappelli, P. (2008). *Talent on demand: Managing talent in an age of uncertainty*. Harvard Business Press. Chapter on internal mobility.

Hewlett, S. A. (2013). *Forget a mentor, find a sponsor: The new way to fast track your career*. Harvard Business Review Press. Chapter 1.

**HOW TO USE THESE**

These are the Week 9 set readings. Buckingham and Clifton (2001) is the core reading for this lecture.

# Sources for this lecture (1 of 4)

Works named on the slides of this lecture. They are background sources, not set readings.

Aguinis, H., Gottfredson, R. K., & Joo, H. (2012). Delivering effective performance feedback: The strengths based approach. *Business Horizons, 55*(2), 105–111. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.bushor.2011.10.004

Bouskila-Yam, O., & Kluger, A. N. (2011). Strength based performance appraisal and goal setting. *Human Resource Management Review, 21*(2), 137–147. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.hrmr.2010.09.001

Clifton, D. O., & Harter, J. K. (2003). Investing in strengths. In K. S. Cameron, J. E. Dutton, & R. E. Quinn (Eds.), *Positive organizational scholarship* (pp. 111–121). Berrett Koehler.

# Sources for this lecture (2 of 4)

Grant, A. M., & Schwartz, B. (2011). Too much of a good thing: The challenge and opportunity of the inverted U. *Perspectives on Psychological Science, 6*(1), 61–76. https://doi.org/10.1177/1745691610393523

Kaiser, R. B., & Overfield, D. V. (2011). Strengths, strengths overused, and lopsided leadership. *Consulting Psychology Journal: Practice and Research, 63*(2), 89–109. https://doi.org/10.1037/a0024470

Kluger, A. N., & DeNisi, A. (1996). The effects of feedback interventions on performance: A historical review, a meta analysis, and a preliminary feedback intervention theory. *Psychological Bulletin, 119*(2), 254–284. https://doi.org/10.1037/0033-2909.119.2.254

# Sources for this lecture (3 of 4)

Kluger, A. N., & Nir, D. (2010). The feedforward interview. *Human Resource Management Review, 20*(3), 235–246. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.hrmr.2009.08.002

Linley, A. (2008). *Average to A+: Realising strengths in yourself and others*. CAPP Press.

Peterson, C., & Seligman, M. E. P. (2004). *Character strengths and virtues: A handbook and classification*. Oxford University Press.

Seligman, M. E. P., & Csikszentmihalyi, M. (2000). Positive psychology: An introduction. *American Psychologist, 55*(1), 5–14. https://doi.org/10.1037/0003-066x.55.1.5

# Sources for this lecture (4 of 4)

van Woerkom, M., & Meyers, M. C. (2015). My strengths count! Effects of a strengths based psychological climate on positive affect and job performance. *Human Resource Management, 54*(1), 81–103. https://doi.org/10.1002/hrm.21623